

Eritrea



A small, hot country on the Horn of Africa, Eritrea won independence from Ethiopia in 1993 after a 30-year war with Ethiopian troops, which left a legacy of destruction and further war. Vast, but as yet, unexploited copper resources around the rugged mountains have potential for development. Eritrea's strategic Red Sea coastal position gives it access to the sea's oil fields, fishing grounds, and useful trade routes.



ERITREA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Asmara
AREA	117,680 sq km (45,405 sq miles)
POPULATION	3,920,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Tigrinya, Arabic
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Christian, Muslim
CURRENCY	Nakfa



Subsistence farming

More than 80 per cent of Eritreans live by subsistence farming, many of them as nomadic herders. Farmers depend on September rains to create seasonal rivers that water the harvest, but recurring droughts have meant that Eritrea has been forced to rely on food aid from overseas.

People

The long war of independence developed a strong sense of nationalism among the people, although they belong to several ethnic groups speaking different languages. Women, 30,000 of whom fought in the war, many at leadership level, have been pressing the government for equal rights in the country's new political constitution.

Somalia



An arid, flat country bordering the Indian Ocean, Somalia has some of the longest beaches in the world. The country gained independence in 1960, but since the late 1980s the south has been in the grip of civil war, waged by wealthy rival warlords, and has had no effective government. Most people are poor, and live in coastal towns in the north and in the south near rivers.

SOMALIA FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Mogadishu
AREA	627,340 sq km (242,216 sq miles)
POPULATION	10,100,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Somali, Arabic
MAJOR RELIGION	Muslim
CURRENCY	Somali shilling



Mogadishu

Conveniently situated on Somalia's coastline, Mogadishu has long been an important port. Arabs founded the capital more than 1,000 years ago, and sold it to the Italians in 1905. In 1960, it was returned to Somalia. The city's buildings are a mixture of older Arab architecture and 20th-century Italian design, but many have been damaged by war.

Civil war

Traditionally, the Somalis were organized in clans, or loyal family groups, that were controlled by elder members. The government destroyed the clan system in the 1980s, provoking bitter wars. Many people are now dependent on overseas aid.



Ethiopia



The Great Rift Valley, a high plateau, and an arid desert dominate Ethiopia. The country has suffered famine, drought, and civil war, but farming reforms and good seasonal rains have enabled Ethiopians to depend less on aid from abroad. Four-fifths of the population make their living through farming. Unique traditions like storytelling, music, and dance are an important part of everyday life.

Food

Spicy foods are standard in Ethiopia. A hot sauce, known as *wat*, is served with beef or chicken, and mopped up with bread. Usually, a soft, flat bread called *enjera* is eaten, which is made from teff, a field crop grown mainly in Ethiopia. A wide range of fish is available to those with money. Ethiopian *kaffa*, coffee flavoured with rye, is known as "health of Adam".



Orthodox Church

The Ethiopian Orthodox Church is the chief Christian faith in the country. The pilgrimage centre of Lalibela, in Ethiopia's central highlands, is known for its Christian churches, which date from the 10th century. *Timkat*, a yearly festival, is celebrated by many Ethiopian Christians.

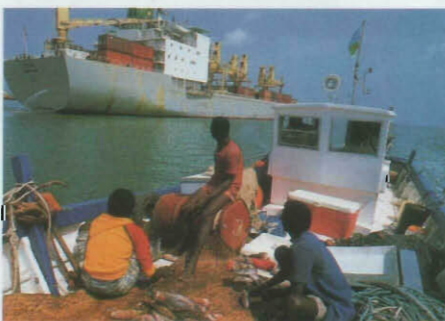


Orthodox priests

Djibouti



A desert country on the Gulf of Aden, Djibouti serves as a port for Ethiopia. The two ethnic groups, the Afars and Issas, have a tradition of nomadic herding, but now half of them live in settled homes in the capital, Djibouti.



DJIBOUTI FACTS

CAPITAL CITY	Djibouti
AREA	23,200 sq km (8,958 sq miles)
POPULATION	638,000
MAIN LANGUAGES	Arabic, French
MAJOR RELIGIONS	Muslim, Christian
CURRENCY	Franc

Shipping and fishing

The 19th-century city of Djibouti is one of the key Red Sea ports in the area, and generates much of the country's income. The fishing industry thrives on its rich waters.